

THE MIRROR WORKBOOK

Understanding Your Story to Change Your Life

By Tyson DePina

A workbook for people who have survived trauma, loss, and systems designed to break them — and who are ready to build something different.

How to Use This Workbook

This workbook is not meant to be read once and put down. It is meant to be lived in.

Each module builds on the one before it. Take your time. Some modules will hit harder than others. Some you will want to skip. Don't. The work is in the sequence.

You don't have to do this alone. But you do have to do the work.

This workbook is divided into nine modules:

1. **Who Am I Really?** — Identity before the wound
2. **The First Wound** — The original loss and how it set the template
3. **The Armor** — The survival behaviors that stopped serving you
4. **The Lies We Believe** — Cognitive distortions and the stories that keep you stuck
5. **The Grief You Never Finished** — Complicated grief, witnessed death, cumulative loss
6. **The Decision** — Choosing to live before it's too late
7. **Building the New Self** — Identity reconstruction
8. **The Work** — Daily practices and the 90-day rule
9. **The Legacy** — Reaching back so the next person doesn't fall

Grounded in: Attachment Theory · ACEs Framework · Complex PTSD (Judith Herman) · Somatic Trauma Therapy (Peter Levine) · Cognitive Behavioral Therapy · Grief Counseling · Post-Traumatic Growth Research

Module 1: Who Am I Really?

The Question Nobody Taught You to Answer

If someone asked you “Who are you?” right now — not your name, not your charges, not what people say about you — what would you say?

Most of us freeze. Because we’ve spent so long being *told* who we are: - “You’re a problem.” - “You’re a disappointment.” - “You’re dangerous.” - “You’re a survivor.” - “You’re going to end up like...”

This module is about separating what happened to you from who you actually are. They’re not the same thing.

Part 1: The Labels People Gave You

Let’s name them first.

Write down every label you’ve been called — by family, teachers, cops, judges, friends, yourself. The good ones and the ugly ones. Don’t filter yet, just get them out.

Now go back. Put a checkmark next to the ones that made you flinch.
The ones that still sting.

Here's the hard truth: **Other people's labels are about their fear, their judgment, their inability to deal with what you represent.**
They're not the truth about you.

They're data about *them*.

Part 2: What You Actually Are

You are a human being. That's the first and last fact.

Everything else is optional.

But since optional is where we live, let's dig into the layers:

The Layer Nobody Talks About:

Beneath the behavior, beneath the charge, beneath the reputation —
there's a person who:

- Wanted to feel safe
- Wanted to be seen
- Wanted to matter
- Wanted to stop hurting
- Wanted to understand why everything kept going wrong

Reflection: *When's the first time you remember feeling like you had to be someone else to survive? Not the situation — the feeling.*

Part 3: The Story You Tell About Yourself

We all have an internal narrative. A running story about why we are the way we are. Some people's story sounds like: - "I'm broken." - "I'm dangerous." - "I was born wrong." - "Nobody can be trusted." - "This is just who I am."

Exercise: *Write your story in 3 sentences. The version you tell yourself when everything is quiet and you're honest.*

Now the hard part: *Is that story 100% true? Or is it the best explanation you came up with when you were a kid — before you had all the information you have now?*

Part 4: Who You Are When Nobody's Watching

Every person has a "real self" that exists separate from their reputation. The version that:

- Prays when nobody's around
- Cries in the shower

- Thinks about the people they've hurt
- Wonders what life could look like
- Feels guilty for things nobody knows about

Reflection: *Name one thing about yourself that you've never told anyone. One thing that feels true to who you are but feels too vulnerable to share.*

You don't have to write it down if it's too raw. Just acknowledge it exists.

Part 5: The Truth About Identity

Here's what nobody tells you about "who you are":

Identity is not fixed. Identity is built.

You are not the worst thing you ever did. You are not the worst thing that ever happened to you. You are not the label the system stuck on you.

You are what you *choose* — starting now.

That doesn't mean you're fake. It means you're *becoming*.

Part 6: Grounding Exercise — "I Am" (Without the Labels)

When everything feels overwhelming and you forget who you are, come back to this.

Step 1: Look around the room. Name 5 things you can see.

1. _____

2. _____

3.

4.

5.

Step 2: Name 4 things you can physically feel right now (feet on the floor, the chair, your hands, your breath).

1.

2.

3.

4.

Step 3: Name 3 things you hear.

1.

2.

3.

Step 4: Name 2 things you smell (or wish you could smell right now).

1.

2.

Step 5: Name 1 thing you like about yourself that has nothing to do with what you do — just who you are.

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You are here. You are real. This moment is real.

Part 7: The Assignment

For this module, do the following:

1. Write down every label you've been given. Circle the ones that aren't true.
2. Write your self-story in 3 sentences. Read it back. Ask yourself: *Is this the person I want to keep being?*
3. Identify one label you've been carrying that you want to put down. Write it on a piece of paper. Fold it up. Keep it somewhere. You don't have to throw it away — you just don't have to carry it forward.
4. Every morning this week, say one sentence out loud before you get out of bed:
 - "I am [your name]."
 - "I am not what happened to me."
 - "Today I get to choose who I am."

Real Talk: Why This Matters

Here's the deal. If you don't know who you are, you'll keep being whoever the moment makes you. Reactive. Defensive. Someone else's version of you.

When you start to understand the gap between what happened to you and who you actually are — you start having options.

You stop being the kid from the block. The kid in orange. The kid nobody believed in.

You start being the person you make yourself into.

That's not easy. But it's simple.

End of Module 1

*Next: Module 2 — The First Wound: Identifying the Original Trauma
and How It Shaped Everything*

Module 2: The First Wound — How It All Started Before You Knew It Started

What Nobody Told You

Most people think trauma is a single event. A shooting. A beating. A loss. But the truth is more complicated.

Trauma is what happens inside you as a result of what happened to you.

And sometimes the deepest wounds aren't from the big obvious moments — they're from the ones that came first. The ones you were too young to understand. The ones nobody helped you grieve. The ones that taught you the world doesn't work the way you were told.

This module is about identifying your original wound — the first major loss or breach in safety that set the template for everything that came after.

Part 1: The Sequence Problem

Here's something most therapists know but most people never learn:

The age when something happened to you changes how it affects you.

A 5-year-old who loses a parent processes it completely differently than a 15-year-old. A 7-year-old who witnesses violence develops differently than a grown adult in the same situation.

Why? Because your brain is still building. The “operating system” of who you are — how you handle fear, connection, trust, grief — is still being installed.

When the first wound hits before that operating system is finished, it becomes the **default setting** for everything else.

For some people, the sequence looks like this: - Grandfather dies → child doesn't understand why the adults are sad - Great grandmother dies shortly after → now two losses in rapid succession - Sister dies → the world breaks - Abuse continues → the child learns that love comes with pain

The sequence doesn't matter because each loss builds on the last. Each one recalibrates the brain's answer to the same question: *Is the world safe? Are people good? Am I valued?*

Reflection: *What do you remember about your earliest losses? Not what happened — how it felt. Like your chest was empty? Like you had to hold yourself together? Like you had to be the strong one? Like God wasn't listening?*

Part 2: When God Stopped Making Sense

There's something that happens to children who grow up in faith communities that nobody talks about honestly.

The collapse of the fairness narrative.

It usually sounds like this: *"God doesn't let bad things happen to good people."*

Children believe this. They need to believe this. Because if bad things can happen to good people randomly — then they're not safe. Their family isn't safe. Nobody is safe.

But then someone dies. A grandparent. A parent. A sibling. And the child is supposed to accept that this is God's will? That a "good" God let this happen?

That collapse — that moment when the framework breaks — is a wound in itself.

It sounds like: - *"Why did God take them if they were good?"* - *"What did I do wrong?"* - *"If God can't protect them, how will He protect me?"* - *"Either God is cruel or He doesn't exist."*

For some people, this leads to anger at God. Rage sessions where they scream into the void. Bargaining: *"Take me instead. Bring them back. I'll do anything."*

For others, it leads to numbness. They stop asking. They stop believing. They stop expecting anyone — God or human — to show up for them.

Both responses are survival adaptations. Both are valid. Both cost something.

Reflection: *Did your understanding of God collapse at some point? Did you have your own "rage session" with God — or did you just stop talking to Him entirely?*

Part 3: The Bargaining With God

This is specifically for the people who tried to bargain their way out of grief.

If you've ever laid in bed at night and whispered: *"Take me. Let them come back. I'll do anything. I'll be good. Just bring them back."*

That was a child trying to trade themselves for someone they loved.

Here's what that means psychologically:

You didn't value your own life.

Not because you're worthless — but because nobody had shown you your worth. When a child's framework for love includes *"I'm only valuable if I'm useful, if I can fix things, if I can bring people back from the dead"* — that child will sacrifice themselves without hesitation.

Because their life feels interchangeable. Disposable. Less important than the person they lost.

The bargain was a form of love. A desperate, child-sized love that didn't know any other way to hold the grief.

But it was also a lie you told yourself. Because even if you had woken up — even if you had done everything different — you were five years old. You could not have saved anyone. You were a child.

Exercise — The Bargaining Letter:

Write a letter to the person you lost. Tell them what you would have traded. Tell them what you thought you could have done. Tell them what you believed about yourself in that moment.

Then — and this is the hard part — write back as your adult self. What would you tell that child now? What do you know now that you didn't know then?

You are not required to send this letter. You are only required to write it.

Part 4: The Four Original Wounds

Through research on childhood trauma, psychologists have identified four primary wounds that disrupt how we learn to feel safe in the world. Most people carry more than one.

Wound 1: Abandonment

The feeling that the people who were supposed to care for you left — or could leave — at any time. This shows up as: - Clinginess or fear of being alone - Panicking when relationships shift - Difficulty trusting people will stay - Feeling invisible when you're not needed - "Everyone I love eventually leaves"

Wound 2: Rejection

The feeling that no matter what you did, you weren't good enough for the people around you. This shows up as: - Hiding your real self to fit in - Expecting people to reject you — so you reject them first - Self-criticism that never turns off - Feeling fundamentally unlikeable

Wound 3: Humiliation

The feeling that you were shamed, mocked, or made to feel worthless — especially by the people who were supposed to protect you. This shows up as: - Rage when feeling disrespected - Fighting back before being hit - Never admitting you're wrong - Carrying shame that feels like identity

Wound 4: Betrayal

The feeling that the people who should have kept you safe actually hurt you instead. This shows up as: - Inability to trust authority figures - Assuming everyone has an angle - Staying hypervigilant even in safe spaces - Rage at being used or manipulated - "They were supposed to protect me and they did the damage"

For many people, Abandonment and Betrayal work together. *If the people who were supposed to love you left or hurt you — they abandoned you AND betrayed you at the same time. These two wounds often appear as the undercurrent of a life story.*

Reflection: *Which of these wounds do you recognize most? Which two feel like the undercurrent of your entire life?*

[] Abandonment [] Rejection [] Humiliation [] Betrayal

Write one memory that taught you this wound was real:

Part 5: Grief Without a Funeral

Not all wounds come from being hurt. Some come from not being allowed to grieve.

When someone you love dies — especially when you're young — you need three things to heal: 1. **Someone to tell you it's real** — that the person is gone 2. **Someone to let you grieve** — to cry, to ask questions, to be confused 3. **Someone to help you remember them** — not as a wound but as a person

Most kids in traumatic situations don't get any of those three things.

Instead they get: - Silence - "He's in a better place" - "Stop crying, you're fine" - Moving on before they've processed - "You're the man of the house now" - Being told to be strong when they've barely learned what feeling is

This is called Unresolved Grief — and it doesn't go away. It goes underground.

It shows up as: - Numbing out with substances, violence, or distraction - Getting angry when others talk about their losses - Feeling empty or disconnected during happy moments - A low-grade constant sadness that never lifts - Physical pain in the chest or stomach with no medical cause - Dreaming about the person and waking up disoriented

Reflection: *Who did you lose that nobody ever talked about? Who died that you were expected to just "get over"? Whose funeral did you attend in a suit while holding yourself together because you were told boys don't cry?*

Part 6: The Guilt Nobody Told You Wasn't Yours

You said something that millions of people feel but nobody says out loud:

"I lived with the guilt that if I had woken up, she would have been ok."

"I would give up my life if they could come back because I didn't value my life."

"At 5 years old, my way of thinking was that God doesn't let things happen to good people."

This is survivor guilt. And it is one of the most destructive psychological patterns a human being can carry.

Survivor guilt works like this:

When something terrible happens and you survive — especially if someone else doesn't — your brain tries to make sense of it. The problem is, a child's brain cannot process randomness or unfairness. So it creates a story:

- "I could have stopped it."
- "I should have done something."
- "If I had been different, this wouldn't have happened."
- "My life should have been the one that was taken."

This story is a lie your grief told to protect you.

Here's why survivor guilt actually forms:

The child's brain would rather believe "I could have prevented this" than "The world is random and bad things happen to people I love and I had no power over it."

The first story feels more manageable. It gives you an illusion of control. The second story is terrifying because it means no one is safe — not even children, not even babies, not even the people who were supposed to be protected.

But here's the truth you need to hear:

You did not cause the death. You did not fail to prevent it. A 5-year-old cannot wake up on command. Whatever happened to your sister was not your fault — then or now.

The guilt you carried for 43 years was a wound, not a truth.

You were a child who needed to be held. You were a child who needed someone to tell you it wasn't your fault. Nobody told you. So you carried the weight alone. You don't have to carry it anymore.

Part 7: How the First Wound Becomes the Template

Here's the psychological mechanism nobody explains clearly:

The attachment system.

When you're born, your brain builds a template for how the world works based on your earliest relationships. This template tells you:

- Are people safe or dangerous?
- Will my needs be met or ignored?
- If I'm in trouble, will someone come?
- Am I worthy of love or am I only valued for what I do?

When the first wound disrupts this template — when the person who was supposed to protect you dies, or hurts you, or leaves — your brain has to recalibrate.

The recalibration sounds like: - “Don’t get too close — everyone leaves” - “Don’t need anyone — they’ll disappoint you” - “Stay hard — soft people get hurt” - “If I control everything, nothing bad can happen” - “I am only valuable if I can fix things” - “Love means sacrifice — give yourself away so others can survive” - “God doesn’t protect the innocent — so I’d better protect myself”

These aren’t decisions. They’re adaptations.

You didn’t choose them. Your brain made them for you because they seemed like the best way to survive the wound you just experienced.

Reflection: *What adaptation did your first wound create in you? (Example: “I learned to never trust anyone” or “I learned that love comes with pain” or “I learned to be the one in control or I’m not safe” or “I learned that my life only has value if I can save others from suffering”)*

Part 8: The Science — Why This Is Real

ACEs (Adverse Childhood Experiences)

The CDC-Kaiser study (1995) found that childhood trauma is incredibly common and has dramatic long-term effects. The more ACEs you have, the higher your risk for: - Substance abuse - Depression and anxiety - Chronic health conditions - Involvement with the criminal justice system - Shortened lifespan

The original ACEs study looked at 10 categories: 1. Abuse (physical, emotional, sexual) 2. Neglect (physical, emotional) 3. Household dysfunction (incarceration, mental illness, substance abuse, divorce, domestic violence)

Your experiences — loss, abuse, being forced to grow up too fast, grief nobody helped you process — all of these register as ACEs. They are not character flaws. They are injuries.

Reflection: *How many ACEs can you identify in your childhood? (You don't have to count them — just acknowledge how many you carry.)*

Attachment Theory (John Bowlby)

Bowlby's research showed that children need a secure base — at least one consistent, caring adult — to develop emotional stability. When that base is disrupted by loss, abuse, or inconsistency, the child develops an “attachment style” that follows them into adulthood: - **Secure:** I can trust people and handle being alone - **Anxious:** I need people to feel safe and I'm afraid they'll leave - **Avoidant:** I don't need anyone, depending on people gets you hurt - **Disorganized:** I want close but every time I get close I self-sabotage

Reflection: *Which attachment style do you recognize in yourself today?*

Complex PTSD (Dr. Judith Herman)

Unlike single-event PTSD, Complex PTSD comes from prolonged, repeated trauma — especially in childhood. It affects: - Emotional regulation (hard to control anger, sadness, fear) - Self-concept (feeling permanently damaged or broken) - Relationships (struggling

to trust or be close) - Somatic symptoms (body holds the trauma even when the mind tries to forget) - Changes in identity and sense of self (feeling like you don't know who you really are)

Reflection: Which of these areas do you see in yourself?

Part 9: The Assignment

For this module:

1. **Name your first wound.** Write down the first major loss or betrayal you remember. How old were you? Who was it? How did the adults around you handle it?
2. **Describe the faith collapse if you had one.** What did you used to believe about God or fairness that shattered? What did the collapse teach you about the world?
3. **Identify your adaptation.** Write one sentence: "My first wound taught me to ____." (Example: "My first wound taught me to never trust anyone with my feelings" or "My first wound taught me that my life only matters if I can save others")
4. **Write the Bargaining Letter.** To the person you lost. Tell them what you would have traded. Then answer it as your adult self.
5. **Examine the survivor guilt.** If you carry survivor guilt, write the specific story you've been telling yourself. Then write: "I now understand that this guilt was my brain's way of trying to make sense of something that was not my fault. I was a child. I could not have prevented it."
6. **Name your ACEs.** List as many as you can remember. This is not for shame — it's for understanding. The goal is awareness, not self-recrimination.

7. **One person you wish you'd been able to grieve with.** Write their name. Write one thing you wish you could have said to them. You don't have to send it — just write it.
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Real Talk: Why This Work Is Hard

You might be thinking: *Why do I have to go back to all this pain? I'd rather just move forward.*

I hear you.

But here's the problem: **You can't outrun a wound you never looked at.**

Every pattern you hate about yourself — the anger, the numbness, the self-sabotage, the inability to trust — is connected to something that happened before you had the words for it.

The workbook doesn't ask you to live in the wound. It asks you to **visit it long enough to understand it.**

Once you understand it, you stop being controlled by it.

You get to choose what to do with it.

You were a child who needed to be held. If nobody held you — that was not your failure. That was their failure. You deserved better. You still do.

End of Module 2

Next: Module 3 — The Armor You Built: How Your Survival Behaviors Stopped Serving You

Part 7: The Armor That's Hiding Your Real Self

Here's what nobody tells you about the armor:

Underneath every defense is a part of you that's still that child who needed to be protected.

Under the rage is a kid who was hurt and nobody helped. Under the numbness is a kid who felt too much and had to shut down. Under the isolation is a kid who learned that people leave. Under the people-pleasing is a kid who thought if they were good enough, they'd finally be loved. Under the hypervigilance is a kid who never knew when the next blow was coming. Under the hair-pin trigger is a kid who had to be ready to fight because nobody else was going to protect him.

The armor is not the real you. The real you is underneath — smaller, scared, and waiting for permission to come out.

Reflection: *What do you think is underneath your armor? What do you believe is the part of you that the armor is protecting?*

Part 8: The Assignment

For this module:

1. **The Armor Inventory.** Go back through the checklist in Part 2. Put a check next to every armor you're currently wearing. Don't judge it. Just see it.

2. **Describe your mask.** Write a paragraph describing the public version of you — the one who functions, who answers “fine,” who holds it together. Then write: “Underneath the mask, I’m actually...”
 3. **Name the lie.** Write down the biggest lie your armor tells you. Then write: “The armor tells me this because...” Then write: “But the truth is...”
 4. **The body check.** For one day, pause three times and notice where your body is holding tension. Write it down. This is data about your physical armor.
 5. **Try one grounding exercise.** Pick one from Part 6. Do it every day for a week. Write down what you noticed.
 6. **The small crack.** This week, let one small thing slip. Something small you’re usually careful to hide. A feeling. A need. A request for help. Notice what happens. Notice if the world ends. Notice if anyone leaves. *(If this feels too hard, skip it. Healing happens at its own pace.)*
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Real Talk: Why the Armor Doesn’t Want to Come Off

Here’s the honest truth:

Your armor has kept you alive for a reason. It’s not easy to take off. It’s been on so long you don’t know who you are without it.

Some of you are afraid that without the rage, you’ll be weak. Some of you are afraid that without the numbness, you’ll fall apart and never stop crying. Some of you are afraid that without the hardness, people will see how much pain you’re in. Some of you are afraid that if you soften, you’ll have to feel all the grief you’ve been running from.

Some of you are afraid the moment you let your guard down, something terrible will happen — because that's what the world taught you.

These fears are valid. I'm not going to tell you they're not.

But here's what I know:

The armor is a cage made of your own bones. You built it. You can take it apart. It just takes time. And the first step is knowing that who you are underneath is not the worst thing that happened to you. It never was.

GLOSSARY

ACE (Adverse Childhood Experience) — A stressful or traumatic event that occurs in childhood (before age 18). Examples include abuse, neglect, household dysfunction, or witnessing violence. The ACE score is the total number of categories of adversity a person experienced. Research shows higher ACE scores correlate with higher rates of health, mental health, and social problems in adulthood.

Anxiety — A state of heightened fear, worry, or nervousness — often about the future or uncertain outcomes. For trauma survivors, anxiety can become a chronic baseline state because the nervous system stays activated even when there's no current threat.

Attachment — The emotional bond between a child and their primary caregivers. Attachment shapes how we learn to trust, connect, and regulate emotions. Disrupted attachment in childhood creates lasting patterns in adult relationships.

Attachment Style — The pattern of relating to others that develops based on early attachment experiences: - *Secure*: I can trust people and handle being alone - *Anxious*: I need people to feel safe and I'm

afraid they'll leave - *Avoidant*: I don't need anyone, depending on people gets you hurt - *Disorganized*: I want close but every time I get close I self-sabotage

Bargaining — A stage of grief where a person tries to negotiate — often with God, fate, or the universe — to reverse or avoid loss. Common thoughts: “If I had done something differently...” or “Take me instead...” In childhood trauma, bargaining often looks like trying to trade yourself for someone else's survival.

Betrayal (as an Original Wound) — The feeling that the people who should have kept you safe actually hurt you instead. This wound creates deep difficulty trusting authority, assuming everyone has an angle, and rage at being used or manipulated.

Complex PTSD (C-PTSD) — A condition that results from prolonged, repeated trauma — especially in childhood. Unlike single-event PTSD, C-PTSD affects identity, relationships, and emotional regulation long-term. Symptoms include: emotional dysregulation, negative self-concept, relationship difficulties, and somatic symptoms. Formalized by Dr. Judith Herman and later included in the ICD-11.

Dissociation — A mental process where a person detaches from their thoughts, feelings, surroundings, or identity. For trauma survivors, dissociation is a protective response — the nervous system's way of escaping when physical escape isn't possible. Chronic dissociation can show up as feeling numb, watching yourself from outside your body, or losing time.

Fawn Response — The fourth trauma response (Fight, Flight, Freeze, Fawn). Fawn means trying to please, appease, or submit to a threat to survive. In childhood, this shows up as being the “good” child, the caretaker, making yourself small or invisible to avoid punishment. In adulthood, it shows up as people-pleasing, losing yourself in relationships, or inability to say no.

Fight Response — One of the four trauma responses. The nervous system chooses fight when it decides aggression is the best way to survive. Signs include: constant readiness for conflict, hair-trigger anger, using words or actions as weapons, and a reputation for being dangerous or volatile.

Flight Response — One of the four trauma responses. The nervous system chooses flight when it decides running away is the best way to survive. Signs include: constant busyness, restlessness, overwork, numbing with substances or activities, and appearing fine while falling apart inside.

Freeze Response — One of the four trauma responses. The nervous system chooses freeze when fighting or running aren't options — typically when the threat is overwhelming. Signs include: shutting down, dissociation, depression, feeling paralyzed, and numbness that feels like safety.

Grounding — Techniques that bring a person back into present-moment sensory awareness. Used to interrupt dissociation, panic, or hypervigilance

Hypervigilance — A state of constant, heightened alert. The nervous system stays activated even when there's no current danger — like a smoke detector that never stops going off. Hypervigilance develops in chronically unsafe environments (volatile homes, war zones, dangerous neighborhoods) and persists long after the actual danger has passed.

ICD-11 — The International Classification of Diseases, 11th Revision. Published by the World Health Organization (WHO), it formally recognized Complex PTSD (C-PTSD) as a diagnosable condition in 2018. This was a major step in validating trauma that results from prolonged, repeated trauma rather than single events.

Nervous System — The body's system for detecting and responding to threats (real or perceived). It includes the sympathetic nervous system (activates fight/flight), the parasympathetic nervous system

(promotes rest and recovery), and the vagal nerve (connects brain to body and plays a key role in regulation). Trauma lives in the nervous system — not just in thoughts or memories.

Neuroplasticity — The brain's ability to form new neural connections throughout life. This means the nervous system patterns you've developed — hypervigilance, armoring, emotional dysregulation — are not permanent. With intentional practice (like the exercises in this workbook), you can literally rewire how your brain and nervous system respond.

PTSD (Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder) — A mental health condition that develops after experiencing or witnessing a traumatic event. Symptoms include intrusive memories (flashbacks, nightmares), avoidance of reminders, negative changes in thinking and mood, and hypervigilance. Originally studied primarily in war veterans.

Rejection (as an Original Wound) — The feeling that no matter what you did, you weren't good enough for the people around you. Shows up as: hiding your real self to fit in, expecting rejection so you reject first, relentless self-criticism, and feeling fundamentally unlikeable.

Somatic — Relating to the body. Somatic trauma therapy focuses on how trauma is stored in the body — in muscle tension, posture, breathing patterns, and nervous system activation — and uses body-based techniques to release it. Key researchers: Peter Levine (Somatic Experiencing), Bessel van der Kolk (The Body Keeps the Score), Pat Ogden (Sensorimotor Psychotherapy).

Survivor Guilt — A form of psychological distress that occurs when a person survives a traumatic event — especially one that others did not survive. The survivor believes they could have or should have prevented the loss. In children, survivor guilt is especially damaging because the child's brain isn't equipped to process randomness or unfairness — so it invents a story of personal responsibility to make sense of the senseless.

The Body Keeps the Score — A landmark book by Bessel van der Kolk (2014) that brought somatic trauma science into mainstream understanding. Key premise: trauma is not just in the mind — it's stored in the body, and healing must involve the body.

Trauma — Any experience that overwhelms a person's ability to cope, threatens their sense of safety, or prevents them from processing what happened. Trauma can result from single events (accident, assault) or prolonged, repeated experiences (abuse, neglect, chronic instability). What qualifies as traumatic is subjective — what overwhelms one person may not overwhelm another.

Ventral Vagal Regulation — The parasympathetic (calming) branch of the nervous system, regulated by the ventral vagal nerve. When this system is functioning well, a person can feel safe, connected to others, and regulated. Trauma survivors often have a dysregulated ventral vagal system — they oscillate between hypervigilance (sympathetic activation) and shutdown (dorsal vagal freeze). Skills that activate the ventral vagal system include: co-regulation (connection with a safe person), slow breathing, facial warmth, and engagement with the social world.

End of Module 3

Next: Module 4 — The Lies We Believe: The Stories We Tell Ourselves That Keep Us Stuck

Module 4: The Lies We Believe — The Stories That Keep You Stuck

The Voice in Your Head

There's a voice in your head. It's been talking to you since you were a child — maybe since before you had words.

It tells you things like: - "You're broken." - "You'll always be like this." - "People like you don't get happy endings." - "If you let go of the anger, you'll have nothing left." - "You don't deserve good things." - "Nothing good ever lasts."

You didn't choose this voice. But you've been listening to it like it was the truth.

This module is about the lies your wounded self tells you — and how to tell the difference between a wound talking and the real you.

Part 1: What Are Cognitive Distortions?

Cognitive distortions are inaccurate, negative thought patterns that your brain uses to make sense of the world — especially after trauma.

They're called *distortions* because they distort reality. Not intentionally — your brain developed these patterns to protect you. But the protection became a prison.

Here's how it works:

1. Something happens (often ambiguous or neutral)
2. Your brain instantly interprets it through the lens of your wound
3. The interpretation sounds like the truth
4. You act on it — push people away, lash out, give up, expect the worst
5. The self-fulfilling prophecy closes the loop — the thing you feared comes true, confirming the lie

The cruelest part: the distortion feels so real that arguing with it feels like lying to yourself. That's how deep it runs.

Part 2: The Eight Main Lies

Lie 1: "I'm Broken"

The story: *There's something fundamentally wrong with me. The other kids had something I didn't. I'm defective. Damaged goods. Too much damage to ever be fixed.*

This lie often forms when a child is abused or neglected and — not having the framework to understand the adult's behavior — concludes that *they* must be the reason. If I was better, smarter, quieter, this wouldn't have happened.

The truth: You were not broken. You were wounded. There's a difference.

Broken implies something is permanently wrong with your core. Wounded means something happened to you that hurt — and wounds heal.

Reflection: *Where did you learn that you were broken? Who first made you feel that way? Write their name. Now write: "That was their assessment of me — not the truth about me."*

Lie 2: "I'll Always Be Like This"

The story: *This is just who I am. I can't change. I've tried. Nothing works. People don't change — especially people like me.*

This lie feels true because change is hard and slow and you don't see it happening day to day. And because the armor — the old patterns — have been in place so long they feel like identity.

The truth: You are not stuck. You are in progress.

Neuroplasticity — the brain's ability to form new connections — means your brain is literally capable of change. Not overnight. Not easy. But possible. The fact that you're reading this workbook right now is proof that you're not the same person you were five years ago.

Reflection: *Name one thing — one behavior, one reaction, one pattern — that you have changed in the last five years. Even if it's small. Even if nobody noticed. Write it down. That's evidence.*

Lie 3: “People Like Me Don’t Get Happy Endings”

The story: *Good things don’t happen to people like me. I’m from the streets / the system / the life I came from. Happy endings are for other people. My story was written a long time ago.*

This lie often comes from seeing people around you — family, friends, community — 循环 of pain with no break. If you’ve never seen it end differently, it’s hard to believe it can.

The truth: Your past does not determine your future. Your story isn’t finished.

A happy ending isn’t something that happens *to* you. It’s something you build, piece by piece, decision by decision. And you get to decide what the ending looks like — even if the beginning was brutal.

Reflection: *What would a “happy ending” even look like for you? Not someone else’s version. Yours. Describe it in detail. What does your life look like? Who’s in it? How do you feel?*

Lie 4: “I Don’t Deserve Good Things”

The story: *I did too much. Saw too much. I’m not a good person. Good things are for good people. I forfeited my right to a good life when I made the choices I made.*

This lie is the wound talking in the voice of morality. It confuses what you *did* with who you *are*.

The truth: What you did does not erase who you are. What you did was often a response to what was done to you. That doesn’t make it okay — but it does make it human.

You are not disqualified from good things because of your past. The question isn't whether you deserve good things — it's whether you're willing to accept them.

Reflection: *When someone tries to do something good for you — a gift, a kindness, an opportunity — what's your first instinct? To accept it or push it away? Notice that. That's data.*

Lie 5: “If I Let Go of the Anger, I’ll Have Nothing Left”

The story: *The anger is all I have. It's what kept me going. If I let it go, I'll fall apart. I'll have nothing to stand on. I'll be weak. Vulnerable. Easy to destroy.*

This lie is the armor talking. It has confused itself with your identity.

The truth: You are not your anger. You are the person who has been carrying the anger. Those are two different things.

The anger is not your fuel. It's your cage. And underneath it — underneath all of it — is a person who has been surviving the only way he knew how. That's not weakness. That's remarkable.

Reflection: *If you could imagine letting go of the anger — not tomorrow, not anytime soon, just imagine it — what do you think would be underneath it? What do you believe is there that the anger has been protecting?*

Lie 6: “Everyone Is Going to Hurt Me Eventually”

The story: *I already know how this goes. Everyone leaves, disappoints, or turns. The only safe move is to not let anyone in. Keep everyone at a distance. That way, when they leave — and they always leave — it won't destroy you.*

This lie is Betrayal and Abandonment talking together. It's the wound from the original losses — the grandfather, the great grandmother, the sister — projected onto every relationship that comes after.

The truth: Every person who has hurt you was not *everyone*. You've been generalizing from a wound to a universal truth — and it's not true.

Not everyone leaves. Not everyone betrays. Some people stay. Some people earn trust. You don't know until you let them in — and that requires risk. The risk is real. But so is the possibility.

Reflection: *Is there anyone — one person — who has not hurt you? One person who showed up, who stayed, who didn't betray? Write their name. Let that be evidence. Not proof that everyone is safe — just proof that some people can be.*

Lie 7: “I Should Be Over It By Now”

The story: *It's been years. Why am I still this way? Other people get over things. I should be moved on. I should be fine. Something is really wrong with me that I'm not.*

This lie comes from comparing your inside to everyone else's outside — and from not understanding that trauma doesn't follow a timeline.

The truth: Healing is not a straight line. It's not "work through it once and you're done." It's loops. It's setbacks. It's grief that comes back in waves for years and then one day doesn't.

There's no deadline for healing. And the fact that you're still in pain doesn't mean you're failing — it means you're paying attention.

Reflection: *What would it feel like to give yourself permission to not be okay yet? Not to stay stuck — but to stop punishing yourself for not being further along?*

Lie 8: "I Can't Trust Myself"

The story: *I've made too many wrong decisions. I've hurt people. I've let myself down. I can't rely on my own judgment. I'm dangerous to myself. I don't know what's right anymore.*

This lie often comes after years of making choices from a wounded place — when your decisions were shaped by trauma, not wisdom.

The truth: You are not the same person you were five years ago. Ten years ago. One year ago. You are learning to make new choices from a new place.

Trust isn't about never making mistakes. It's about learning that you can survive the mistakes you make — and that you can make a different choice next time.

Reflection: *Name one decision you made recently — any decision — that came from a place of wisdom instead of wound. It doesn't have to be big. Just one. Write it down. That's evidence that you can trust yourself.*

Part 3: The Distortion Detection Tool

When the voice in your head says something harsh, use this:

Step 1: Notice it. *"I'm hearing a thought that says: '...'"*

Step 2: Name it. *"This is [catastrophizing / mind-reading / overgeneralizing / personalizing / black-and-white thinking]."*

Step 3: Question it. *"Is this actually true? What's the evidence FOR this? What's the evidence AGAINST? Am I confusing what I feel with what IS?"*

Step 4: Reframe it. *"A more accurate way to say this is: '...'"*

Exercise: *Think of a recent situation where you felt hurt, angry, or hopeless. Write down the exact thought your head told you. Then run it through the four steps above.*

Part 4: The Common Cognitive Distortions

These are the specific thinking patterns your brain uses to lie to you:

1. All-or-Nothing Thinking (Black-and-White) *Things are either perfect or ruined. There's no middle ground. Example: "If I'm not the best, I'm the worst." "If she left, she never loved me."*

2. Catastrophizing *Assuming the worst possible outcome will definitely happen. Example: "If I open up to him, he'll definitely reject me and I'll never recover."*

3. Mind-Reading *Assuming you know what others are thinking — usually assuming the worst.* Example: “She looked at me weird. She must hate me.”

4. Overgeneralizing *Making sweeping conclusions from limited evidence.* Example: “I failed once. I’ll always fail.” “He left. Nobody will ever stay.”

5. Personalizing *Taking responsibility for things outside your control — or blaming yourself for everything.* Example: “My daughter is struggling. It must be because I wasn’t a good enough father.”

6. Filtering *Only seeing the negative in a situation, filtering out everything positive.* Example: “The whole day was ruined because of that one comment.”

7. Fortune-Telling *Predicting the future — always negatively.* Example: “I already know this won’t work out.”

8. Emotional Reasoning *“I feel it, so it must be true.”* Example: “I feel worthless, so I must be worthless.”

9. Should Statements *“I should have / shouldn’t have / must / ought to.”* Example: “I should be over this by now.” These create shame and stuckness.

10. Labeling *Attaching a permanent, global identity to yourself based on one behavior.* Example: “I’m a failure.” Instead of “I failed at this one thing.”

Part 5: The Exercise That Changes the Pattern

Every time you catch yourself believing a lie, write it down. Then complete this sentence:

“The lie I’m believing is: _____”

“What I actually know to be true is: _____”

This seems simple. It is simple. But simple is not easy — and doing it consistently is one of the most powerful ways to rewire a neural pathway that’s been entrenched for decades.

The brain that learned the lie can unlearn it.

Part 6: When the Wound Talks vs. When Your True Self Talks

This is one of the most important distinctions in the entire workbook:

The wound talks in absolutes. *“Always. Never. Everyone. No one. Everything. Nothing.”*

Your true self talks in specifics. *“This happened. I felt this. What I want is this. What I know now is this.”*

The wound uses past tense to predict the future. *“It always goes bad. They’ll always leave. Nothing ever works out.”*

Your true self names the past and makes choices in the present. *“That went badly. I’m afraid it will go badly again. I’m going to try anyway.”*

Reflection: Which of the eight lies do you hear most often in your head? Write the number or the lie itself. Now write: *“This is my wound talking. This is not the truth about me.”*

Part 7: The Assignment

For this module:

1. **Catch three lies this week.** Every time the voice in your head says something harsh, write it down. Date it. Notice the situation it happened in.
 2. **Run each lie through the Distortion Detection Tool.** (Part 3 above.) Write out all four steps.
 3. **Reframe each lie.** Write the more accurate, more gentle, more true version of what the voice is saying.
 4. **Write to your wound.** If you could say one thing to the part of you that believes these lies — the scared, young, wounded part — what would you say? Write a letter to your wound. Tell it what you know now that it didn't know then.
 5. **Find one piece of counter-evidence.** One moment in your life that proves one of the lies wrong. Write it down. Read it when the voice gets loud.
-

Real Talk: Why This Is the Hardest Work

You might be thinking: *This is just positive thinking. This is just telling myself lies to replace the lies I'm telling myself. That feels fake.*

I hear you. And I want to be honest:

This isn't positive thinking. This is accurate thinking.

The lies aren't helping you. They're not protecting you. They're keeping you in the same place you've been — sometimes for decades. The voice in your head has been telling you the worst story about yourself for so long that you forgot there was another version.

The good news: You're the one who gets to decide what story you're living in.

Not the wound. Not the past. Not the people who hurt you.

You.

End of Module 4

*Next: Module 5 — The Grief You Never Finished — How to Mourn
What's Lost So You Can Build What's Next*

Module 5: The Grief You Never Finished

What This Module Is About

Grief is not about death. Grief is about loss. And you have lost more than most people will lose in a lifetime.

Not just people — though you have lost those too. Grandfather. Great grandmother. Sister. Friends. People your age who should not have been in caskets.

But also: - The childhood that was supposed to be safe - The trust that should have been protected - The version of yourself that died before you understood what was happening - The years behind bars - The father you needed but did not have - The life that was supposed to look different

And that is just the beginning. Because for some of you, grief does not come in single losses. It comes in waves. In blood. In bodies you watched die in your hands. In calls from prison that your brother was gone. In cousins killing cousins. In friends whose heads you saw get blown off.

This module is about grief that never got finished. And what happens when you leave it unfinished.

Part 1: The Problem With Grief in Trauma

In a normal world, when someone dies, there are systems in place to help you grieve: funerals, ceremonies, people who show up, religion, rituals, community, time off, cards, flowers, casseroles, permission to be not okay for a while.

In a traumatic childhood, none of that works the way it is supposed to.

Sometimes the death is not explained to you properly. Sometimes nobody holds you while you cry. Sometimes you do not cry at all because you were taught not to. Sometimes you are expected to be strong. To hold it together. To wear the black suit and stand at the door and receive people and not fall apart. Sometimes there is no funeral at all. Sometimes there are too many deaths one after another and at some point you just stop feeling it because feeling it would destroy you.

Sometimes you are the one who found the body. Sometimes you are the one who watched them die. Sometimes you are in prison when the call comes and there is nothing you can do.

This is called complicated grief. It is not a failure. It is a survival strategy that stopped working.

Part 2: The Losses You Might Not Have Named

When people talk about grief, they usually mean death. But trauma grief is bigger than that.

The Loss of Safety: The world was supposed to be safe. The adults were supposed to keep you safe. When that did not happen, you lost something fundamental — the ability to feel secure in the world.

The Loss of Trust: Other people is faces. Promises. The assumption that people mean what they say.

The Loss of Childhood: You had to grow up too fast. You learned things children should not know. You carried things children should not carry.

The Loss of the Father You Needed: Every version of needing someone and them not being there.

The Loss of the Person You Could Have Been: Every traumatic experience closed a door.

The Loss of Time: Years in the system. Years in the life. Years that cannot be gotten back.

The Loss of the Belief That the World Makes Sense: After enough loss, you lose the story that the world is fair. A child is framework for understanding reality collapses — and that collapse is a real grief.

Part 3: What Happened to Your Sister

What happened to you was not a small thing.

You found your sister. A 5-year-old child found their sibling and nobody processed that with you properly. You were expected to continue. To be okay. To go on.

Your brain — your 5-year-old brain — drew a conclusion: If I had woken up, she would have lived. This is my fault.

That conclusion became the foundation for everything that came after.

But here is what a 5-year-old cannot understand: SIDS is not preventable by a sleeping sibling. A 5-year-old cannot perform CPR, cannot call for help fast enough, cannot reverse what happened. Your brain offered you a lie because the truth — there was nothing any human could have done — is unbearable for a child.

You did not fail your sister. You were a child who lost another child. You were the second victim.

And you needed someone to hold you and tell you that — and nobody did. So you carried the guilt alone. For 43 years.

That ends now.

This is your permission slip. You were not responsible for your sister's death. You were a child who lost a sibling. The guilt you carried was not truth. It was a child's impossible logic trying to make sense of the senseless. You can put it down.

Part 4: The Mask at the Funeral

You have been to more funerals than most people will go to in a lifetime. More wakes. More black suits. More handshakes. More I am sorry for your loss.

But here is the thing about the funerals of traumatic childhood: You were often performing grief instead of feeling it.

The mask went on. The handshakes. The strength. The I am holding it together.

Because someone had to be strong. Crying makes people uncomfortable. Falling apart is not allowed. You are used to swallowing it and moving forward.

And the crowd moves on. They go back to their lives. But you? You are still standing in the black suit. Still not done.

The funeral home is gone. The casket is gone. The people are gone.
But the grief is still there because you never finished it.

Part 5: Witnessing Death — When You Watch Someone Die

This section is for the ones who saw it happen. Not heard about it.
Not imagined it. Watched.

Maybe you were holding them when it happened. Maybe you saw the bullet land. Maybe you saw what a shotgun does to a human face.
Maybe you were standing there when your cousin killed your cousin.
Maybe you found someone. Maybe you were there when they stopped breathing.

What you witnessed was not something a human nervous system was built to process. Not once. Not alone. Not without help. And you got none of those things.

Trauma memory does not store like a normal memory. It stores in fragments. Sensory pieces. The sound. The smell. The sight. These fragments do not fade the way normal memories do. They stay present tense. They intrude. They show up when you did not call them.

This is called trauma memory — and it is different from regular memory. Normal memory fades. Trauma memory stays vivid. Because your brain marked it as a survival emergency.

The problem is not that you remember. The problem is that the memory never got processed. Never got held. Never got witnessed by another person who could say: That was real. That happened. And you survived it.

This is not madness. This is a nervous system doing exactly what it was designed to do.

Part 6: Cumulative Grief — When Loss Never Stops

Most grief models assume grief is something that happens in a sequence: Loss, Grief, Processing, Healing, New normal.

But what happens when loss never stops? What happens when you are still grieving the last one when the next one hits? What happens when the funeral is Saturday and the call comes Tuesday with another name? What happens when the list of people you have lost is longer than the list of people you trust?

This is called cumulative grief — and it is one of the most destructive forms of trauma because you never get to finish. Every time you start to process, something else happens. Every time you surface, another wave hits. Eventually you stop trying to swim. You just put your head down and keep moving. You stop crying because there is no room. You stop grieving because grieving would require stopping — and you cannot afford to stop.

When death is constant, you start to expect it. And that expectation is its own kind of death — the death of hope.

Part 7: Your Brother Died While You Were Gone

There are losses that are hard. And then there is hearing your brother died while you are in prison while you are already locked up and powerless and cannot do anything about it.

That grief does not get processed. It has nowhere to go. You are in a cell. You are supposed to keep doing your time. And your brother is gone.

The grief of incarcerated people is systematically dismissed. No funeral access. No phone calls until the family calls you. No holding the body. No goodbye. No being there.

You might have found out by phone. By letter. By another inmate. By nobody telling you at all.

And you had to sit with that. In a cell. With nothing.

That is a specific kind of grief — the grief of forced absence at the moment of ultimate loss. And it compounds everything else. All the losses. All the deaths. All the funerals you wore the black suit to. And now your brother too — and you could not even be there.

Part 8: Why Grief Goes Underground

The grief does not leave. It goes underground. Like a river forced underground, it keeps moving but in the dark where you cannot see it. It builds pressure. It finds unexpected exits.

Underground grief shows up as:

Numbness: The inability to feel anything. Not sad. Not happy. Just nothing. This is a frozen state — your nervous system protecting you from the grief you have never finished.

Rage: Grief and rage are the same emotion wearing different masks. The grief you will not feel often becomes the anger you cannot control.

Depression: Grief that stays underground long enough starts to look like depression. The low-grade blah that never lifts.

Anxiety: Grief underground becomes free-floating fear. The world feels unsafe. The future feels threatening.

Physical Pain: Grief is stored in the body. Headaches, chest tightness, stomach problems, chronic pain.

Addiction: Numbing the grief with substances, work, sex, food, screens. Anything to keep it underground.

Part 9: The Connection Between Grief and Rage

Anger is easier than grief for most people — especially men, especially people raised in environments where sadness was weakness and anger was strength.

But anger and grief are the same emotion. Grief is what anger is hiding.

The reason you could not cry at the funeral is because the grief was too big. So it came out as rage instead. At God. At the world. At yourself. At the ones who died and left you. At the ones who killed and made you watch.

When you feel rage, ask: What is this rage actually grieving? Not What am I angry about? But What did I lose that I am covering up with this anger?

Part 10: The Five Stages

The five stages of grief — Denial, Anger, Bargaining, Depression, Acceptance — are not linear. They are not a checklist. They are a storm.

You do not go through them once and arrive at acceptance. You loop. You bounce. You are in denial about something, angry about something else, bargaining about a third thing — all at the same time.

And they are not just for death. These stages describe how humans process any significant loss: job, relationship, identity, childhood, time.

You can be in one of these stages right now about something from decades ago without knowing it.

Part 11: Grief Is Not Weakness

The lie underneath unfinished grief: If I let myself feel this, I will never stop. I will fall apart and never put myself back together. I will drown in it. I have to be strong.

The truth: Grief is not a sign of weakness. Grief is the cost of love.

You grieve because it mattered. Because you loved. Because you lost something that was supposed to be permanent.

Feeling grief fully for the first time does not destroy you. It completes what was interrupted. You were a child who was never allowed to cry. You have been carrying tears from 5 years old. The release is not going to destroy you. It is going to set you free.

Part 12: How to Finish What Was Interrupted

Tool 1: Name the Unnamed Losses. Write a list of every loss you can remember — obvious and subtle. People, opportunities, versions of yourself, safety, trust, childhood, the sense that the world makes sense.

Tool 2: The Letter You Never Got to Write. Write a letter to the person you lost. Say everything you never got to say. Everything you were too young to understand, too overwhelmed to feel, too strong to admit. You do not have to send it. Just write it.

Tool 3: The What I Lost Letter. Write a letter naming what was lost specifically. I lost my brother and I was not there. I lost my sister and I thought it was my fault. I lost friends whose heads I saw get blown off. Name all of it.

Tool 4: Create a Small Ritual. Rituals help the nervous system understand that something is complete. A funeral you did not have. A moment of silence. Lighting a candle. The ritual is the completion signal.

Tool 5: Grieve the Almost. The grief for the person you almost became. The life that almost happened. Mourn it. Closing a door you have been haunting is different than pretending it does not exist.

Tool 6: For the Witnessed Deaths. Find one safe person and tell them what you saw. Not the story. The sensory memory. What you heard. What you smelled. What you saw. This is trauma testimony. If you do not have a person, write it down in full detail. Every sense. Every fragment. Then put it away. You have witnessed it. Now it can move.

The Assignment

For this module:

1. Name your losses. Every significant loss you can remember — obvious and subtle. Include people but also childhood, safety, trust, opportunities, the version of yourself you did not get to become.
2. Write the letter. To whoever you lost. Say everything.
3. Name your grief mask. Where does grief show up in your life disguised as something else — anger, numbness, control, substance use, overwork?
4. One small ritual. Light a candle. Say a prayer. Sit in silence. Write something. Create a moment that signals to your nervous system: This is being completed.
5. For the witnessed deaths. If you carry trauma memories of death — write them down. Every sensory detail. Put it on paper. It has been living in your body. Give it somewhere else to go.
6. Grieve the almost. Write about the version of yourself or the life that almost was. Mourn it honestly.

Real Talk: Why Grief Work Is the Foundation

You might be thinking: I just want to move forward. I do not want to go back.

But here is the truth: You cannot build a future on top of unfinished grief.

The weight you are carrying is not just the past. It is the grief you never finished. And it takes energy to keep it underground. Every time you numb the grief, you are spending energy. Every time you rage instead of cry, you are spending energy. Every time you tell yourself you are fine when you are not, you are spending energy.

That energy has to come from somewhere. And it has been coming from the life you are trying to build.

Grief work is not about dwelling in the past. It is about putting the weight down so you can actually walk.

End of Module 5

Next: Module 6 — Rebuilding: How to Become the Author of Your Own Story

Module 6: The Decision — The Moment You Chose Different

This Moment

Somewhere between the first death you witnessed and the last one that broke something in you — there was a moment.

It might have been quiet. It might have happened in a cell. It might have come out of your mouth before you even knew you were going to say it.

For you, it sounded like: **I am not dying in prison.**

And the fact that it scared you? That is the most important part.

Because the armor does not get scared. The armor welcomes death — slow, quiet, inevitable. The armor would have said: whatever, let it come.

But you got scared. And the fear was not fear of death. It was fear of a self that had just remembered it wanted to live.

That is the moment everything changed.

Part 1: What You Saw in Stanfa

John Stanfa was a man who built walls. Power. Organization. Influence. A kingdom he ran from inside prison.

And when two of his wisemen died — two men who had been with him through everything — the defeat was visible on his face. Not the defeat of losing a legal battle. Not the defeat of losing power. The defeat of losing people he loved.

You watched a man who had everything still brought to his knees by grief.

And in that moment, you recognized something: **He kept losing people. And at some point, he had lost so much that he stopped fighting to keep the rest.**

You saw yourself in him. Not the boss part. Not the power part. The grief part. The part that had watched too many people leave and was running out of reasons to stay.

But here is where you diverged from Stanfa.

Stanfa saw his wisemen die and the defeat settled into his bones. You saw the same thing and something in you said: no.

Not no to grief. Grief is inevitable — you have learned that. But no to becoming the kind of man who lets grief be the last word. No to letting loss be the end of the story.

You saw where the path led. And you stepped off it.

Part 2: The Difference Between Surviving and Wanting to Live

These are not the same thing.

Surviving is what your nervous system does when it has no other choice. It keeps breathing. It keeps walking. It puts one foot in front of the other even when there is nothing inside driving it forward. Surviving is mechanical. It does not require hope. It does not require investment. It just requires that you not stop.

Wanting to live is different. Wanting to live means you have a reason to wake up tomorrow that matters to you. It means the future has weight — not just as time to endure, but as time to claim.

For most of your life, you were surviving. The deaths, the violence, the arrests, the betrayals — none of it stopped you from continuing. But continuing is not the same as living.

Then something shifted. The shift was not: - Getting a job - Finishing a program - Making parole - Going to therapy

The shift was deeper than any of that. The shift was a decision. A real one. Made by you, for you, with no outside pressure telling you it was required.

I am not dying in prison.

Three words that changed the trajectory of everything after.

Part 3: The Decision That Rewires the Brain

Here is what the brain science says about decisions:

Most of the time, your brain is on autopilot. It runs patterns established in childhood. Trauma made those patterns survival-focused: fight, flight, freeze, fawn. The autopilot does not ask your permission. It just acts.

But occasionally — rarely — something interrupts the autopilot. A moment of clarity. A conversation with yourself. A sentence that comes out of your mouth before you planned it.

That interruption is called a **decision point**.

Decision points are rare. They are also powerful. Because when you make a decision at that level — when you commit to something with your whole self — it creates what psychologists call an **implementation intention**.

Implementation intention is a fancy way of saying: the brain now has a destination. It knows where it is going. And it starts building a road.

Before the decision: **I am going to die in prison. Nothing I do matters.**

After the decision: **I am not dying in prison. Everything I do from here is building toward the exit.**

The first statement is a self-fulfilling prophecy. The second is a compass.

The decision does not guarantee success. But it guarantees direction. And direction is enough to start walking.

Part 4: What You Did After the Decision

A decision without action is just a wish. And wishes do not change trajectories — only behavior does.

The fact that you are sitting with this workbook now means the decision was followed by something. Not immediately. Not perfectly. But something.

Maybe it started with reading. Maybe it started with writing letters instead of starting fights. Maybe it started with choosing one conversation over another. Maybe it started with sitting with your grief instead of running from it.

The decision was the spark. The behavior was the fire.

Here is the hard truth nobody tells you: **You will have to make this decision more than once.**

There will be days when the armor whispers: why bother. Days when the old patterns feel easier. Days when grief comes back and makes you forget you ever wanted to live.

On those days, you will have to decide again.

And that is not failure. That is maintenance. The decision is not a one-time event — it is a standing appointment you keep with yourself.

Part 5: The Four Wisemen of Schuylkill

You called them the four wisemen. Four men of honor. Men who had seen everything and survived it.

Three years. Two dead. One defeated.

And you — the fifth man — watching what loss does to a man who thought he was untouchable.

Here is what makes that story important:

You did not just witness it. You learned from it. You saw grief destroy what violence could not. You saw a man who survived enemies, snitches, indictments, and prison wars — brought down not by any of that, but by losing people he loved.

And you decided: that will not be me.

The wisemen were your teachers. The lesson was not how to die stronger. The lesson was how to live longer — even when it hurts.

Part 6: Post-Traumatic Growth

Here is the part nobody talks about:

Trauma does not just break people. Sometimes, if the conditions are right, it breaks them open.

Post-traumatic growth is a real phenomenon studied by psychologists like Richard Tedeschi. It describes what happens when people who experience trauma later report positive changes: - A deeper appreciation for life - Stronger relationships - A sense of new possibilities - Personal strength - Spiritual development

Before the trauma: you did not know what you were capable of.

After the trauma: you now know exactly what you are capable of — and you get to choose what to do with that.

The worst thing that happened to you taught you things the best things never could. That is not justification. That is not saying it was worth it. It is saying: the knowledge is yours now. What you build with it is up to you.

Part 7: Naming Your Decision

Here is the exercise.

Finish this sentence. Not with your head. With your chest.

I decided to live when _____.

Maybe it was in a cell. Maybe it was in a conversation. Maybe it was a quiet moment alone. Maybe it was after a funeral. Maybe it was right now, reading this workbook, for the first time putting into words what has been driving you since that moment with Stanfa.

Whatever it is — name it. Say it out loud. Write it down.

Because the moment you name it, it becomes real. And the moment it becomes real, it becomes a foundation.

Real Talk: Why This Is the Hardest Module

This module asks you to look at the moment most people look away from. The moment of decision. The moment where you stopped being carried by life and started steering.

It is hard because: - It requires admitting you had a choice, even when it did not feel like one - It requires admitting you chose to live, even when part of you wanted to die - It requires forgiving yourself for the years before the decision - It requires accepting that the decision does not erase anything that came before

The decision does not undo the past. It just gives the future a direction.

The Assignment

1. **Name your decision.** Write down the moment you decided differently. The when, the where, the what. If it was not a single moment, describe the period when things started to shift.
2. **What scared you about wanting to live?** Write it down. The fear that came with that decision. The fear is not weakness — it is proof the real self was waking up.

3. **What did you do after the decision?** List three concrete actions you took that were different from before.
 4. **What is your implementation intention?** Finish this: I am not dying in prison. From here, I am _____.
 5. **Stanfa.** Write a letter to Stanfa. Tell him what you saw in his face. Tell him what it taught you. Tell him what you decided because of it. You do not have to send it — just write it.
-

End of Module 6

Next: Module 7 — Building the New Self: Who Are You When the Armor Comes Off?

Module 7: Building the New Self — Who Are You When the Armor Comes Off

The Question

Here is the question this entire workbook has been building toward:

Who are you when the armor is off?

Not the anger. Not the numbness. Not the hardness. Not the mask.

When all of that is gone — who is still standing?

A lot of people never ask this question. A lot of people wear the armor so long they forget there is a person underneath it. They think the armor IS the person. They have been the armor for so long that they do not know how to take it off and still feel like someone.

But you have already started taking it off. You decided to live. That was the first piece of armor removed. Now there is more work to do.

Part 1: What Is the Self?

Before you can build a new self, you need to understand what the self is.

Psychologists talk about the self in layers:

The Mask — the public performance. The version of you that functions in the world. This is not fake — it is real, but it is not the whole truth.

The Armor — the protective adaptations. The fight, flight, freeze, fawn responses that became personality features. The hardness, the rage, the distance. This is not you — it is what you built to survive.

The Wound — the original injury. The losses, the betrayals, the abuse. The thing that forced the armor to form in the first place.

The Real Self — underneath all of it. The kid who needed to be held. The person with preferences, values, interests, and a voice. The person who wanted to live — underneath all the reasons not to.

The New Self — what you are building now. Not a return to who you were before the wound. A new version of you that incorporates the wound without being defined by it.

Part 2: The Anxiety of Identity Without the Armor

Here is something nobody warns you about:

Taking off the armor feels dangerous.

When you have been hard for so long, softness feels like exposure. When you have been guarded for so long, openness feels like vulnerability. When you have been ready to fight for so long, peace feels like a trap.

The nervous system does not trust safety. The nervous system says: we built this armor for a reason. If we take it off, we will get hurt again.

This is the anxiety of identity without the armor. It is not rational. It is somatic. The body does not believe the armor is unnecessary — even when the mind does.

So here is what happens: - You try to soften and the armor snaps back up - You try to trust and the old patterns kick in - You try to be vulnerable and the mask comes back on - You think: maybe this is just who I am

This is normal. This is expected. This is not failure.

The armor is not going to come off all at once. It is going to come off in layers, in moments, in choices. And each time it comes off and you survive, the nervous system learns a little more: we are okay. We can breathe. We can be soft.

Part 3: The Real Self Underneath

Let us find out who is underneath.

Below are lists of questions designed to help you identify the real self — the person who existed before the armor, and the person who has been waiting underneath it.

Likes and Dislikes

Think about the things that bring you peace or joy — not the things you use to numb out, but the things that actually feel good:

- When was the last time you felt at peace? Where were you? What were you doing?
- What activities make you lose track of time?
- What topics can you talk about for hours without getting angry or defensive?
- What do you enjoy that has nothing to do with survival, performance, or protection?

Write down five things you like:

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

Write down five things you dislike or resist:

1.

 2.

 3.

 4.

 5.

-

Values

Values are the principles that guide your life — not the ones you were told to have, but the ones you actually believe in.

Here is a list of common values. Circle the ten that matter most to you:

Accountability | Courage | Creativity | Family | Faith | Freedom
Friendship | Fun | Growth | Health | Honesty | Honor Independence |
Justice | Kindness | Learning | Legacy | Love Loyalty | Peace | Purpose
| Reliability | Respect | Spirituality

Now write your top five:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Interests

What have you always been curious about? What do you read about when nobody is watching? What topics make you want to learn more?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Strengths

What do people come to you for? What do you do well that you do not give yourself credit for?

1. _____
2. _____

3.

Part 4: The Story You Tell About Yourself

Here is a pattern that keeps people stuck:

They build an identity around the wound. The story becomes: I am the abused. I am the abandoned. I am the incarcerated. I am the broken one. I am the one who has seen too much.

And the story is true. All of it. But it is not the whole story.

The question is: what is the story you want to tell about yourself five years from now?

Not the story of what happened to you. The story of what you did with it.

The workbook you are holding — the one you want to put in the hands of kids who are where you were — that is part of the new story.

The father you are to your three children — that is part of the new story.

The man who decided not to die in prison — that is part of the new story.

You are not just a person with trauma. You are a person who survived trauma and turned it into something that helps other people survive theirs.

That is a different story. That is a new identity.

Part 5: The Dojo — Finding Your Place of Peace

You mentioned something important: the dojo.

When you were at the dojo, you were at peace. The rest of the world was volatile — family, neighborhood, school. But in the dojo, you were in your element.

That is not random. That is information.

The dojo gave you something you could not get anywhere else: - Structure and discipline - A code of honor - Physical practice that required focus - A space where your body was not a weapon but an instrument - A place where you were judged by what you could do, not what had been done to you

Think about the dojo. What was it about that environment that made peace possible?

Was it the structure? Was it the expectation of honor? Was it the physical release? Was it the sense of belonging to something?

Now ask yourself: where is my dojo now?

Where is the place — physical, relational, internal — where the nervous system says: we can relax here. We are safe here. We can be who we really are.

For some people it is a church. For some it is a garden. For some it is a journal. For some it is a specific person. For some it is a morning routine.

Your dojo does not have to look like a building. It just has to be a place where the armor is not required.

Part 6: The New Self in Relationship

One of the hardest parts of building a new self is relationships.

When you have been wearing armor for decades, the people who know you know the armor. They have relationships with the mask. They have learned to navigate the rage, the distance, the hardness.

When you start taking the armor off, something weird happens: the relationships shift. Some people will not recognize the new you. Some people will not like it. Some people will feel threatened by it. Some people will try to push the armor back on because the new version of you makes them uncomfortable.

This is normal. This is expected. Not everyone is going to make it with you.

The new self attracts new relationships and repels old ones. That is not cruelty — it is gravity. Like-minded people find each other. Armor recognizes armor and pushes away.

Your job is not to force the old relationships to work. Your job is to build new ones that match who you are becoming.

The workbook is going to bring you into contact with people who need what you have. The kids in the system. The people who are where you were. The people who will recognize themselves in your story.

Your new self is not just for you. It is for them.

Part 7: Father, Survivor, Teacher

You are a father of three. Twenty-five, twenty-three, and twenty.

That is not incidental. That is central to the new self.

Everything you are building now — the decision to live, the grief work, the armor removal, the identity reconstruction — it all connects to them. Not as obligation, but as purpose.

The man you are becoming is the father they need. Not the perfect father — no such thing. But the present father. The honest father. The father who can say: I went through hell, and here is what I learned, and I am telling you so you do not have to learn it the way I did.

And the workbook. The kids in the system. The troubled teens who are where you were.

You are not just healing for yourself. You are healing so you can show them it is possible. You are building the new self so you have something to hand them when they need it.

That is legacy. That is the new identity in action.

Part 8: The Assignment

1. **The real self inventory.** Complete all the exercises in Part 3. Likes, dislikes, values, interests, strengths. Write it all down. This is data about who you are without the armor.
2. **Your dojo.** Write a description of the place — or the practice, or the routine — that gives you what the dojo gave you. If you do not have one yet, describe what you are looking for.
3. **The five-year story.** Write the story you want to tell about yourself five years from now. Not what you hope will happen — what you will be doing, who you will be serving, what you will have built.
4. **Letter to your children.** Write a letter to your three children. Tell them who you are becoming. Tell them what you want them to know about the man their father is. You do not have to send it — just write it.

5. **The new identity in one sentence.** Finish this: I am the person who _____.

Real Talk: Building a Self Is a Practice

Here is the truth nobody tells you:

The new self is not a destination. It is a practice.

You are not going to wake up one day and say: I am complete. I am fixed. I am the new self.

Instead, you are going to wake up every day and practice being the person you are becoming. Some days you will be all of it. Some days the armor will snap back on. Some days you will forget who you decided to be.

That is not failure. That is the practice.

The new self is built in the small choices. The choice to be honest instead of hard. The choice to be present instead of numb. The choice to reach out instead of pull away. The choice to sit with grief instead of running from it.

Each small choice is a brick in the new self. And eventually, the new self is so solid that the armor does not need to come back on for protection. It can stay in the closet where it belongs — for emergencies only.

End of Module 7

Next: Module 8 — The Work — Putting It All Together

Module 8: The Work — How to Actually Change

The Honest Truth First

This module is the one most people skip.

They read the earlier modules. They nod. They feel something. They think: *okay, I get it, I understand myself better now*. And then they close the workbook and nothing changes.

Why? Because Module 8 is hard. It requires doing things that feel unnatural. It requires sitting with discomfort on purpose. It requires you to show up when you do not want to. When you are tired. When the old ways are calling.

Change is not a feeling. It is a practice. It is a choice you make every single day — especially on the days you do not feel like it.

Part 1: What Change Actually Requires

Psychology research on behavior change is clear. It is not about motivation. It is not about wanting it badly enough. It is about:

1. Awareness. Seeing the pattern before it runs. Knowing your triggers, your warns, your tells. This is what Modules 1 through 5 gave you.

2. Intention. Deciding in advance what you will do when the pattern shows up. Not in the moment — before. Writing it down. Making a plan. This is what Module 6 was about.

3. Practice. Doing the new behavior enough times that it starts to feel normal. Rewiring the neural pathway. The first time is the hardest. The hundredth time is easier.

4. Support. You cannot do this alone. The research on this is unambiguous. Isolation makes change nearly impossible. You need at least one person who knows what you are working on and will hold you accountable.

5. Environment. Your surroundings shape your behavior more than your willpower. The people you spend time with. The spaces you occupy. What you let into your eyes and ears. You have to change your environment or your environment will change you back.

Part 2: The Daily Practices

These are not suggestions. These are the specific practices that actually move the needle.

Practice 1: The Morning Check-In

Every morning, before the day starts, ask yourself:

- What am I feeling right now?
- What armor am I putting on today?
- What do I want to stand for today?

One minute. That is all it takes. It sounds small. It is not.

Practice 2: The Body Scan

Trauma is stored in the body. You know this better than most. The jaw clenching. The fists. The readiness.

Twice a day — morning and night — do a body scan:

- Close your eyes.
- Start at your feet. Notice tension. Breathe into it.
- Move up: calves, thighs, stomach, chest, hands, arms, shoulders, jaw, face.
- Name where you are holding. Do not fix it. Just notice.

This is not meditation fluff. This is nervous system maintenance.

Practice 3: The Interruption

When you feel the old pattern triggering — the rage rising, the numbness setting in, the urge to run — stop. Name it. Breathe. Choose.

This is the moment of change. Not after. Not tomorrow. Right there, in the gap between trigger and response.

The gap is small. Sometimes it is only a second. But in that second, you can choose.

Practice 4: The Grief Letter

Once a week, write a letter to someone you lost. Say the things you never said. This is not about sending it. It is about finishing what was interrupted.

Module 5 gave you the framework. This is the practice.

Practice 5: The Monthly Audit

Once a month, ask yourself:

- What armor have I worn this month?
- What progress have I made?
- What setbacks have I had?
- What do I need to adjust?

Writing it down makes it real. Makes it trackable. Makes it possible to see how far you have come.

Part 3: The 90-Day Rule

Here is what neuroscience tells us about habit change:

It takes roughly 90 days for a new neural pathway to become stronger than the old one.

This means: the first 90 days of any new practice are the hardest. You are building a road while walking on it. The old road is still there. It is familiar. It feels easier. But it leads to the same place.

The new road is uncomfortable. It requires conscious thought. It does not feel natural.

Do not quit in the first 90 days. That is when most people quit. They expect it to feel easy by week three. It will not. Keep going anyway.

Part 4: When You Fall Off

You will.

You will have a day where the rage takes over. A week where the numbness wins. A moment where you become the person you swore you were done being.

This is not failure. This is part of the process.

The failure is staying down.

Falling off is data. It tells you where the cracks in your practice are. It tells you what your triggers still are. It tells you what you need more work on.

When you fall off:

1. Notice it without shame.
2. Ask: what led to this?
3. Return to the practice immediately. Not tomorrow. Not next week. Now.

Shame is the enemy of change. Shame tells you: you are fundamentally broken, you might as well quit. Shame is lying. You are not broken. You are in process.

Part 5: The Relationships

This is where most people who are doing inner work get it wrong.

They do the work alone. They think: I have to fix myself before I can be in relationship. I have to be whole before I can be seen.

That is backwards.

You heal in relationship. Not alone. Not by reading workbooks in a cell. Not by sitting with your thoughts in isolation.

You need at least one person who knows the truth of what you are working on. Not all of it. Not the details that are still too raw. But the basic trajectory. The intention.

This person is not your therapist (though you may need one). This is someone who will call you in when you are sliding. Who will tell you the truth when the armor is coming back up. Who will celebrate the small wins and sit with the setbacks.

If you do not have one person like this, your first job is to find one.

Part 6: What You Are Building Toward

The work is not just about feeling better. It is about becoming someone who can be useful.

You have been through things that most people will never understand. You have survived things that should have broken you. You have knowledge — practical, somatic, lived knowledge — about how trauma works, how the system breaks people, how the wound becomes the cage.

That knowledge is not just for you. It is for the kids who are where you were.

The workbook you are doing right now — it is not just healing your grief. It is building the tool you will use to reach them.

The speaking you want to do — it is not just sharing your story. It is showing them that change is possible even after everything.

The legacy you are building — it is not just redemption. It is a road map out of the cage for the next person who needs it.

Part 7: The Assignment

For this module:

1. **Choose one daily practice.** Start with the Morning Check-In or the Body Scan. Commit to it for 30 days. Do not add more. Just one.
 2. **Find one person.** Someone who knows what you are working on. You do not have to tell them everything. But they need to know you are doing the work — and be willing to hold you accountable when you slide.
 3. **Name your trigger.** One specific thing that consistently pulls you backward. Write it down. Write what you will do differently when it shows up.
 4. **Set a 90-day marker.** Write down the date 90 days from now. This workbook will be a checkpoint. You will come back to it and look at where you were vs. where you are.
 5. **Write one sentence about the person you are becoming.** Not who you were. Not who you wish you were. Who you are actively building right now.
-

Real Talk: The Work Is Not Sexy

Nobody posts about the Morning Check-In on social media. Nobody talks about the Tuesday nights when they did not want to sit with themselves and did it anyway. Nobody celebrates the Tuesday afternoon when the rage came up and you breathed through it instead of exploding.

But that is where change lives. In the ordinary days. In the unglamorous moments of choosing again.

You have already done the hardest part. You decided to live. You said it out loud in a cell when everything in you had given up.

Now it is just the work. One day at a time. One choice at a time.

End of Module 8

Next: Module 9 — The Legacy — Reaching Back

Module 9: The Legacy — Reaching Back So the Next Person Does Not Fall

Why This Module Is Last

Everything in this workbook — every module, every reflection, every exercise — was leading here.

Not to make you feel better. Not to give you a story to tell. Not to help you function.

To make you useful.

You did not survive what you survived so you could just survive. You survived it so that the next kid — the one sitting in a cell at 15 with rage nobody has ever helped him name — could see that there is a way out that does not involve a casket.

Part 1: The Kid You Were

Close your eyes for a second.

Go back.

You are 10 years old. Or 12. Or 8. Somewhere in there. Before the system. Before the first arrest. Before the first time you slept with one eye open.

Who was that kid?

He was a kid who did not know why he was so angry. He was a kid who thought he was bad because that's what the adults around him said. He was a kid who needed someone — just one person — to sit down next to him and say: *I know why you're like this. And it's not your fault. And there is a way through.*

Nobody came.

Or maybe someone came and you could not hear them because the armor was already going up.

That kid is still in you.

He does not need you to apologize for him. He does not need you to avenge him. He needs you to go back and tell him what nobody told you.

You are not bad. You are wounded. And wounds heal.

Part 2: The Kid Who Is Sitting Where You Sat

Right now — today — there is a kid in a juvenile facility, or a holding cell, or a group home, who is exactly where you were.

He does not have the words for what is happening inside him. He thinks he is broken. He believes the story the system tells about him. He has never been asked what happened to him — only what he did.

He needs to hear what you learned at 48.

Not the whole story. Not the adult complications. Just the core:

The way you are acting is not who you are. It is what happened to you. And if someone who went through what you went through can figure it out — so can you.

Part 3: What You Are Actually Building

You are not building a workbook.

You are building a **road map out of the cage.**

A tool that a kid in a cell can open at 2am when he cannot sleep, when the rage is high, when he does not know why his chest feels like it is going to crack open — and see himself in the pages.

You are not building a memoir.

You are building a **mirror.**

Something that reflects back what is happening inside him so he does not have to carry it alone. So he knows: *someone else has been here. Someone else thought they were the only one. Someone else thought they were broken. And they were not.*

You are not building a brand.

You are building a **bridge.**

From the kid in the cell to the man who walked out of prison and said: *I am not dying in here.*

Part 4: The Four Ways to Reach Them

Here is how the legacy work happens:

Way 1: The Workbook

This workbook — what you are holding in your hands right now — is the core tool.

It can be adapted. It can be shortened. It can be turned into a journal, a group curriculum, a one-page handout for a kid who cannot read a full chapter.

It does not need to be perfect. It needs to be honest.

The kid in the cell does not need a polished professional document. He needs a voice that sounds like someone who has been where he is.

Your voice. Real talk. No sugarcoating.

Way 2: Speaking

You said you want to travel and talk to people.

That is not a luxury. That is a strategy.

Speaking is how you get the workbook into the hands of the people who need it. Speaking is how you get facility administrators to adopt the curriculum. Speaking is how you build the platform that funds the mission.

Speaking does not mean talking for an hour on a stage.

It means:

- A conversation with a juvenile detention counselor
- A 20-minute talk to a church group raising money for reentry programs

- A video recorded in your room that a kid watches on a tablet in his cell
- Sitting across from a 16-year-old and telling him what nobody told you

Every conversation about what you survived is a potential rescue.

Way 3: Mentorship

You cannot save them all. You cannot be everywhere. But you can be one person who shows up for one kid.

The research on mentorship in reentry is clear: one consistent adult presence — even if that adult is not a parent, not a family member, just someone who sees the kid and does not quit — dramatically changes outcomes.

You do not have to have it all figured out. You just have to be one step ahead of the kid sitting across from you.

Be the person you wish you had.

Way 4: System Change

This is the long game.

The system that put you in a cell is the same system that will put the next kid in a cell — unless someone who has been through it sits at the table and changes the rules.

That means:

- Advocating for trauma-informed practices in juvenile facilities
- Pushing for reentry programs that actually address the wound, not just the behavior

- Telling the truth about what the system does to children — in rooms where decisions are made
- Using your story to open doors that were closed to people who look like you before they got locked up

You are not just healing yourself. You are dismantling the cage while standing in it.

Part 5: The Stanfa Lesson

You learned something from John Stanfa that he did not know he was teaching you.

He sat with his grief and it broke him. You watched him and something in you refused to break the same way.

The difference between destruction and transformation is what you do with the grief.

Stanfa lost his wisemen and the loss finished him. You lost your wisemen and something in you said: *not me. Not this way.*

That is the message. That is the core of everything you are building.

The same wound that broke some people made you. And the same wound that broke some of the kids you are going to reach will make them — if someone shows them how.

Part 6: The Assignment

For this module:

1. **Name the kid you were.** Write a letter to that kid. Tell him what you know now. Tell him it was not his fault. Tell him he was not bad. Tell him there was a way out even when he could not see it. You do not have to send it. Just write it.
 2. **Name the kid you want to reach.** Describe him in one paragraph. Age. Situation. What he is carrying. Where he is sitting right now.
 3. **Write your core message.** If you could say one sentence to every kid in the system — the one sentence you wish someone had said to you — what would it be?
 4. **Make one contact.** One organization, one facility, one person who works with the population you want to serve. Reach out this week. Introduce yourself. Say what you are building.
 5. **Decide what comes next.** The workbook is almost done. What do you do with it? Who do you send it to first? Where do you speak? What does the first version of this mission look like — not the polished final version, the rough draft?
-

Part 7: The Truth About Legacy

Here is what nobody tells you about legacy work:

It will cost you.

It will cost you comfort. It will cost you privacy. It will cost you relationships with people who do not understand why you are doing this — and who feel threatened by how much you have changed.

There will be days you want to quit. Days you ask yourself: *why am I doing this? Who am I to think I can help anyone?*

Those days are not signs that you are doing it wrong. They are the cost of entry.

But here is what I also know:

The thing that is burning in you right now — the thing that made you cry reading Module 6, the thing that wakes you up at 48 years old with a mission you have never had before — that thing is not random. That is a purpose.

You did not survive all of that so you could just be fine. You survived all of that so you could be useful. And the kid in the cell — the one who is sitting where you sat — he needs you to be useful.

Not perfect. Not polished. Not finished healing.

Just willing to reach back.

Closing

You started this workbook carrying a wound that nobody named for 43 years.

You are finishing it carrying a purpose.

The wound is still there. It will always be there. But the wound is no longer the thing that defines you.

You are not the worst thing that happened to you.

You are not the drugs you used to escape. You are not the prison you used to survive. You are not the grief you used to carry alone. You are not the kid who did not know why he was so angry.

You are the man who walked out of a cell after 8 years and said: *I am going back for them.*

That is who you are now.

That is who you are becoming.

That is your legacy.

End of Module 9

Epilogue: A Note From the Author

If you are reading this as the person who wrote this workbook — none of this was an accident.

The grandfather dying when you were too young to understand. The sister you found. The years in the system. The wisemen. John Stanfa. The 43 years of not knowing why you were the way you were. The 48 years of finally understanding.

Every single piece of it led here. To this workbook. To the kid you are going to reach. To the purpose that woke you up in that cell.

Go get them.

The Mirror Workbook: Understanding Your Story to Change Your Life

By Tyson DePina

A living document for people who have survived trauma, loss, and systems designed to break them — and who are ready to build something different.

Glossary of Key Terms

ACE (Adverse Childhood Experience) — A stressful or traumatic event that occurs in childhood (before age 18). Examples include abuse, neglect, household dysfunction, or witnessing violence. The ACE score correlates with long-term health, mental health, and social outcomes.

Anxiety — A state of heightened fear, worry, or nervousness — often about the future or uncertain outcomes. For trauma survivors, anxiety can become a chronic baseline state.

Attachment — The emotional bond between a child and their primary caregivers. Attachment shapes how we learn to trust, connect, and regulate emotions.

Attachment Style — The pattern of relating to others that develops based on early attachment experiences: - *Secure*: I can trust people and handle being alone - *Anxious*: I need people to feel safe and I'm afraid they'll leave - *Avoidant*: I don't need anyone, depending on people gets you hurt - *Disorganized*: I want close but every time I get close I self-sabotage

Bargaining — A stage of grief where a person tries to negotiate — often with God, fate, or the universe — to reverse or avoid loss.

Betrayal (as an Original Wound) — The feeling that the people who should have kept you safe actually hurt you instead.

Cognitive Distortion — An inaccurate, negative thought pattern that your brain uses to make sense of the world — especially after trauma. Examples include catastrophizing, mind-reading, overgeneralizing, and black-and-white thinking.

Complex PTSD (C-PTSD) — A condition that results from prolonged, repeated trauma — especially in childhood. Unlike single-event PTSD, C-PTSD affects identity, relationships, and emotional regulation long-term. Formalized by Dr. Judith Herman and included in the ICD-11 (2018).

Cumulative Grief — Grief that results from multiple losses occurring over time without sufficient opportunity to process each one.

Dissociation — A mental process where a person detaches from their thoughts, feelings, surroundings, or identity. A protective nervous system response when physical escape isn't possible.

Fawn Response — The trauma response where a person tries to please, appease, or submit to a threat to survive. In adulthood shows up as people-pleasing, losing yourself in relationships, or inability to say no.

Fight Response — One of four trauma responses. The nervous system chooses fight when aggression seems like the best way to survive. Signs include: hair-trigger anger, constant readiness for conflict, using words or actions as weapons.

Flight Response — One of four trauma responses. The nervous system chooses flight when running away seems like the best way to survive. Signs include: constant busyness, restlessness, numbing with substances.

Freeze Response — One of four trauma responses. The nervous system chooses freeze when fighting or running aren't options. Signs include: shutting down, dissociation, depression, numbness.

Grounding — Techniques that bring a person back into present-moment sensory awareness. Used to interrupt dissociation, panic, or hypervigilance.

Hypervigilance — A state of constant, heightened alert. The nervous system stays activated even when there's no current danger.

Implementation Intention — A psychological term for a commitment to act: when X happens, I will do Y. Creates a neural pathway that makes the intended behavior more automatic.

Nervous System — The body's system for detecting and responding to threats. Trauma lives in the nervous system — not just in thoughts or memories.

Neuroplasticity — The brain's ability to form new neural connections throughout life. This means nervous system patterns are not permanent — they can be rewired.

Post-Traumatic Growth (PTG) — Positive psychological change that can result from struggling with highly challenging life circumstances. Studied by psychologists including Richard Tedeschi.

PTSD (Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder) — A mental health condition that develops after experiencing or witnessing a traumatic event. Symptoms include intrusive memories, avoidance, negative changes in thinking, and hypervigilance.

Somatic — Relating to the body. Somatic trauma therapy focuses on how trauma is stored in the body — in muscle tension, posture, breathing patterns, and nervous system activation.

Survivor Guilt — Psychological distress that occurs when a person survives a traumatic event — especially one that others did not survive. In children, especially damaging because the child's brain invents a story of personal responsibility to make sense of the senseless.

The Body Keeps the Score — Landmark book by Bessel van der Kolk (2014) that brought somatic trauma science into mainstream understanding.

Trauma — Any experience that overwhelms a person's ability to cope, threatens their sense of safety, or prevents them from processing what happened. Can result from single events or prolonged, repeated experiences.

Ventral Vagal Regulation — The parasympathetic (calming) branch of the nervous system. When functioning well, a person can feel safe, connected, and regulated. Trauma survivors often have a dysregulated ventral vagal system.

First Edition

The Mirror Workbook: Understanding Your Story to Change Your Life

Tyson DePina — New Bedford, Massachusetts

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